

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

THE DMK-LED ALLIANCE IS LOOKING TO REPEAT ITS 2019 LOK SABHA SWEEP IN TAMIL NADU. THE AIADMK AND BJP FIGHTING THE ELECTION SEPARATELY SHOULD AID ITS CAUSE, BUT THERE COULD BE SURPRISES IN STORE

BY AMARNATH K. MENON

WILL THE DRAVIDA MUNNETRA KAZHAGAM (DMK) again be the third largest party, behind the BJP and the Congress, in the 18th Lok Sabha? It's a question that's being bandied about in Tamil Nadu a lot these days as the state braces to vote in the first phase of the general election on April 19. The ruling DMK faces a different challenge this time, considering that rivals All India Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the BJP have forged separate alliances, unlike in 2019, to make it a triangular contest. The Tamil nationalist Naam Thamizhar Katchi (NTK) makes the contest, at least on paper, a quadrangular one. NTK had almost 7 per cent vote share in the 2021 assembly polls, finding favour among the younger voters. The party didn't win any seats, but proved it could upset outcomes in close fights.

As you may have noticed, the Congress doesn't figure in the above para—and rightly so. But it's ensconsed within the enduring Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) of the DMK, which has the upper hand this time as well. If they are pulling out all the stops, it's to win all 39 LS seats (it lost only one in 2019). The other SPA constituents are the two Left parties—the CPI and the CPI(M)—the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) and a rainbow of minor Tamil parties. Count here the Dalit party Vidhuthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), the vocal Vaiko's Marumalarchi DMK (MDMK) and the Kongunadu Makkal Desiya Katchi (KMDK) that has support in the western districts, particularly Coimbatore.

Actor Kamal Haasan's Makkal Needhi Maiam (MNM) is also onboard after he struck a deal with DMK supremo M.K. Stalin and famously declared, "I have shaken hands where I should shake hands, not for position but for the sake of the country." MNM is not contesting, but Haasan will be made a Rajya Sabha MP from Tamil Nadu in the 2025 biennial elections. Apart from the SPA allies, niche players such as the Thamizhaga Vazhvurimai Katchi (TVK), led by firebrand T. Velmurugan, and Muslim outfits Manithaneya Makkal Katchi (MMK) and the Manithaneya Jananayaga Makkal Katchi (MJMK) have expressed support.